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POLITICS - 19-year-old candidate not kidding around - Clark aims for Assembly after No. 2 primary finish

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Author: Kevin Modesti | Section: News | 1346 Words
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In some ways, he is very much a kid.

He lives with his mom. He squeezes in time for campaigning between classes at Cal State Northridge and evening shifts at an ice cream shop. He is lean, and his voice and brown eyes are clear and lively.

Walking door to door to drop in on small-business owners along Reseda Boulevard in Northridge one recent afternoon, Justin Clark sports sneakers and jeans. His business-casual shirt appears brand-new, the back of his collar still bearing the transparent sticker listing the shirt's size (small). His campaign manager notices the sticker and peels it off.

"That's embarrassing," Clark says.

There are moments when the 19-year-old seems out of place carrying Republican hopes on his slim shoulders in the June special-election runoff for a seat in the California Assembly representing the west San Fernando Valley.

But then there are times

when an observer can forget Clark's age and see a candidate who might be able to teach more experienced political hands some things about imagination, determination and patience.

A confident Clark leads campaign manager Greg Fuller into the storefront headquarters of Multiplex Business Enterprises and reintroduces himself to owner Qamar Zaman, an accountant. It's a follow-up visit for the candidate, and once again Clark finds himself listening to Zaman talk about the bane of business operators on this block — a Los Angeles city-installed bike lane they say makes customer parking difficult. Zaman goes on in detail for long minutes, and Clark assures him that as an assemblyman he would pay more attention to local businesses' needs than current officials do.

Finally, Clark turns the conversation to the election. Zaman expresses concern about the teenager's inexperience. But the 68-year-old businessman ends up saying he'll vote for Clark.

"The young people should be involved," says Zaman, a native of Pakistan who thinks a (very) young assemblyman can contribute to healthy diversity in the Legislature. "The young people can bring up new problems, new needs, new challenges."

Just one thing, Zaman tells Clark: "Don't stop your education."

Not a total surprise

If Clark wins the June runoff against Democratic attorney Jesse Gabriel, he wouldn't be able to study next semester at Cal State Northridge, where he's a political science major. He tells an interviewer he would look to take online courses during legislative recesses. He has thought ahead about what his precocious political career could mean for his college career.

He has been thinking ahead for years.

His mother, Monique Clark, a property manager, said Justin started talking at age 16 about running for office as soon as he reached California's 18-year-old legal threshold. Justin says it was first suggested by a pair of Calabasas High School teachers who heard him talk about local issues. They meant it as a joke, initially, then turned serious.

"He's just different," his mother said. "He sits in his room and researches and watches stuff. He's been talking politics at the dinner table since he was 4."

The interest in politics and his conservative bent come from Justin's father, Mike Clark. A self-described news junkie, Mike insisted that Justin read the newspaper before he could collect his allowance. Mike taught Justin that it's OK to disagree with people as long as you listen and respect their opinions.

Mike called Justin's fast start in politics "not completely surprising."

"He's put his money where his mouth is," said Mike Clark, who is divorced from Justin's mother and lives in Arizona, where he is fields manager at Tempe Diablo Stadium.

"He wants to effect change. It's easy to sit back and complain. He's actually doing something."

Born in February 1999 in Yorba Linda, Justin has no memory of the Sept. 11, 2001, terrorist attacks and some other events that are basic reference points for most public officials. His first, vague political memory is of George W. Bush's re-election in 2004. By the Barack Obama-John McCain presidential race of 2008, he was paying rapt attention.

In a mock election in school, he supported McCain.

Clark's "reverence for the presidency" is offended by Donald Trump's behavior, but he supports Trump on many issues, including the need for a border barrier (accompanied by reforms to streamline legal immigration). Clark's politics tend toward the libertarian — he's more liberal on social issues. He hates how politicians try to exploit issues like abortion and same-sex marriage.

"I don't like government poking its nose in," Clark says, holding a Starbucks ice tea. "I want to focus on issues where we can agree, because that's where the solutions are. Zero in on social issues because they know they're divisive. Then that makes people unwilling to compromise on other issues.

"My whole reason for running is that government is supposed to be functional. It's supposed to be working for the people. It's not supposed to be an institution that divides people."

Still a long shot

Clark filed paperwork with election officials in 2017 with the intention of challenging Matt Dababneh, the Democrat representing the 45th Assembly District. Then Dababneh was accused of sexual misconduct and, in December, resigned from office. Now there was a special election to fill the rest of the term that ends Dec. 3, as well as an upcoming election for the next two-year term.

In the April 3 special-election primary, Clark finished second with 25.1 percent of the 32,534 votes cast in the district, which covers the west Valley communities of Calabasas, Hidden Hills, Canoga Park, Woodland Hills, West Hills, Winnetka, Northridge, Reseda, Tarzana and Encino, and the Ventura County community of Bell Canyon.

That won him second place behind Gabriel (32.7 percent). Their June 5 runoff is the same day as the primary for the full term, in which Clark, Gabriel and others will compete.

Analysts say Clark advanced because he was the only Republican among eight primary candidates and able to consolidate GOP votes. But the party math that favored Clark in April presents him with a tall task in June. The

district’s voters lean Democratic, giving Gabriel a head start.

Worse for Clark, he says he has only about $2,000 in his campaign accounts (Gabriel reports hundreds of thousands of dollars in contributions) and finds prospective Republican donors hesitant to give to what’s seen as a losing cause.

If Clark has an advantage, it could be that he’s focusing on what he sees as local concerns. Gabriel’s calling card is his role in lawsuits against the Trump administration on behalf of DACA recipients.

Another potential advantage is the endearing novelty of the teenager’s campaign. If he wins, he apparently would become the youngest state legislator, beating the record held by John J. DeHaven, who was 20 when he was sworn in in 1869 as an Assembly member from Humboldt County. (Alex Vassar, a legislative historian with the state library, said birthdates are unknown for more than one-third of the 4,428 people who have served in the Legislature since 1849.)

After one of the Northridge business owners notes Clark’s inexperience and incomplete education, the candidate gamely spins the negative into a positive.

“No one has a degree in everything,” Clark tells a reporter. “Committees used to bring in professionals to give testimony, but nowadays politicians think they know everything. One of the things that makes me appealing is I know my limits. I’m willing to seek out the wisdom of other people, to listen to professionals, to work with community members, to make sure the decisions I’m making are grounded in facts, not some notion I have in my head.”

In a year when young people are widely expected to vote in higher-than-normal numbers — inspired by opposition to Trump and gun violence — Clark is taking activism to a new level.

Cal State Northridge political science professor Larry Becker, who moderated a candidates debate that included Clark, said he was impressed with the teenager’s polish.

“It’s kind of refreshing to see someone who’s young but unafraid to engage in the political process in a pretty substantial way,” Becker said. “It’s not like he did this as some kind of lark. He’s taking it seriously, he’s studied the issues. And he has something to say.

“He’s not a cookie-cutter politician. I’m sure some people will find that to be a selling point.”

kmodesti@scng.com @KevinModesti on Twitter

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